Everyone laughed again. The boys understood the trick, arithmetic had played upon them. What they could not understand was why the teacher later complimented the boy who had asked that absurd question.

The boy had asked a question that had taken mathematicians several centuries to answer. Some mathematicians claimed that zero divided by zero was zero. Others claimed it to be unity. It was the Indian mathematician Bhaskara who proved that it is infinity. The boy who asked the intriguing question was Srinivasa Ramanujan. Throughout his life, whether in his native Kumbakonam or Cambridge, he was always ahead of his mathematics teachers.

- What was the reaction of the classmates to Ramanujan's question?
- What did the Indian mathematician Bhaskara prove?

Ramanujan was born in Erode in Tamil Nadu on December 22, 1887. His father was a petty clerk in a cloth shop. From early childhood it was evident that he was a prodigy. Senior students used to go to his dingy house to get their difficulties in mathematics solved. At the age of 13, Ramanujan was lent a book on advanced trigonometry written by S.L. Loney. Not only did he master this rather difficult book but also began his own research. He came forth with many mathematical theorems and formulae not given in the book, though they had been discovered much earlier by great mathematicians.

The most significant turn came two years later when one of his senior friends showed him the book *A Synopsis of Elementary Results in Pure Applied Mathematics,* a collection of 4865 formulae and theorems without proof by G.S. Carr. For a boy of 16 the title itself must be frightening, but Ramanujan was delighted. He took the book home and began to work on the problems given in it. This book triggered the mathematical genius in him.

Mathematical ideas began to come in such a flood to his mind that he was not able to write all of them down. He used to do problems on loose sheets of paper or on a slate and jot the results down in notebooks. Before he went abroad he had filled three notebooks, which later became famous as Ramanujan's *Frayed Notebooks.*

- Where did Ramanujan get S.L. Loney's book on Trigonometry?
- Where did Ramanujan do his mathematical problems?

Although Ramanujan secured a first class in Mathematics in the matriculation examination and was awarded the Subramanyan Scholarship, he failed twice in his first-year arts examination in college, as he neglected other subjects such as History, English and Physiology. This disappointed his father. When he found the boy always scribbling numbers and not doing much else, he thought Ramanujan had gone mad.

Ramanujan began to look for a job. He had to find money not only for food but for papers as well to do his calculations. He needed about 2,000 sheets of paper every month. Ramanujan started using

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